

All the top range boards for the Intel platform that made it to this comparison were based on a single chipset—the Intel 875P. This new chipset is built (as Intel claims), for one purpose: to provide the ultimate in performance. We intended to find out exactly that.

Gigabyte and MSI are generous when it comes to handing out, what they consider, must-have goodies—five pairs of SATA cables, two power adapters for a SATA hard disk, an attractive, rounded IDE cable, bundled software, flashing LEDs (which make a modded case look really cool), a six-phase power supply for better stability during over clocking, etc. Intel, on the other hand, offers nothing but the bare essentials such as required cables and backplates. Let's dig deep to find out who's the king of the performance hill.

AOpen AX4C Max

Max to the T

The AX4C Max motherboard based on Intel 875P chipset from AOpen, boasts of support for the latest Pentium 4 processors and DDR 400 MHz memory modules. The layout of components is as good as it is bad. The capacitor near the CPU retention mechanism comes in the way of installation, and requires careful handling. The IDE slots, ATX Power connector and memory slots are placed well and aren't cramped. The SATA connectors are lined one after the other, with hardly any space between them—quite irritating if you use more than two connectors.

Though featured packed, it is not in the league of the Gigabyte boards, and offers two Firewire ports, eight USB ports and one Gigabit LAN. Out of the five PCI slots, the one marked in blue can be used for high-power requirement cards such as WiFi, Bluetooth adapters, etc.

The four memory slots can cram in a maximum of 4 GB of memory—provided you buy 1 GB memory modules. The Southbridge provides two SATA ports, the onboard promise controller offers two more ports for RAID 0, RAID 1 and RAID 0+1 modes—it misses out on providing IDE RAID though. The AX4C also has two BIOS chips hardwired on the board, and backup BIOS, in case you blow up the original one. The Watch Dog feature automatically resets the BIOS to default, when the system freezes during overclocking. You can over-clock in steps of 1 MHz, which offers excellent control over the process.

The AX4C Max performed brilliantly, but was edged out by the MSI's 875's mind-boggling performance. One area where the board really lost to the MSI, was *Quake III Arena*. In the SiSoft Sandra CPU test, the AX4C level with the MSI board. In other tests, the AX4C was marginally behind the MSI board.

The AX4C is priced at Rs 15,850, acceptable for boards in this category. There's nothing wrong with this board, but there are better ones in terms of performance, features and price; for those who swear by AOpen, it's a good option.

Price: Rs 15,850

+ Stable performance

- Priced too high

AOpen AX4C Max		B-
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	

Gigabyte GA-8KNXP

Loaded to the boot

Gigabyte sure packed its 8KNXP motherboard to the gills. Based on the Intel 875P chipset, the component layout is good—no capacitors come in the way when installing the CPU.

The locks on the memory slot don't interfere with the AGP card. The floppy connector is behind the power connector, for easy removal, but the same

can't be said for the floppy cable. The IDE connectors are placed quite high up, and this may be inconvenient in case of a small cabinet. The SATA ports are arranged into groups of two, and the IDE RAID ports are placed in the lowermost portion. The Firewire and USB headers are quite awkwardly placed, and the IDE RAID cable comes in the way while connecting respective headers.

The 8KNXP has six memory slots, allowing you maximum flexibility while adding new modules. This board features RealTek's ALC655 sound codec with jack-sensing technology. It also comes with an AGP Pro slot that can take 8x compatible cards. This was the only motherboard to provide both IDE and SATA RAID, with all the three modes of operation—RAID 0, 1 and 0+1. Over-clocking this board is quite simple, with the neat and intuitive BIOS, allowing you to tweak all the necessary parameters in easy steps.

The 8KNXP was only 0.16 units behind the AOpen AX4C, but there was no question of comparing it to the best performer—MSI 875P Neo. The board performed well in most tests, similar to the AOpen board, but couldn't beat the MSI board. Even though it came last in terms of performance, this can't be considered a bad choice because the variation in scores was very small.

At Rs 15,000, the 8KNXP offers great value, considering its packaging. It's not the best performing board, but it's no slouch either. If you like loads of goodies along with your motherboard, apart from reasonably good performance then it has to be this board.

Price: Rs 15,000

+ Great features and package content

- Relatively low on performance

Gigabyte GA-8KNXP		B
Performance	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Features	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Build quality	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	
Value for money	■ ■ ■ ■ ■	